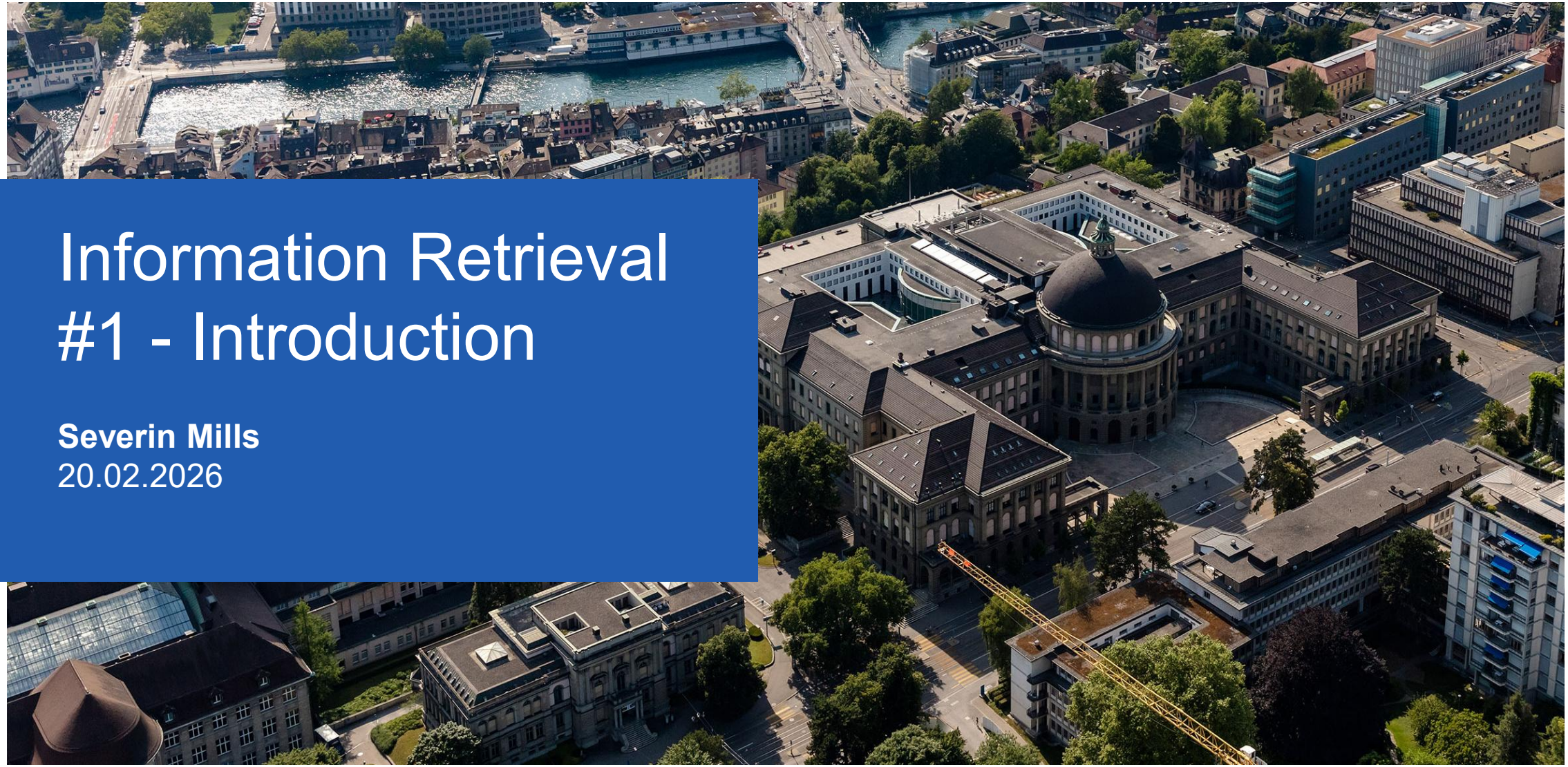
ETH zürich



Information Retrieval #1 - Introduction

Severin Mills

20.02.2026

Agenda

1. Whoami
2. Course Introduction
3. Notebook
4. (Kahoot)

Severin Mills

- 6th Sem BSc
- Second Time as TA in IR
- VIS Board Member (Vice President and Event Organizer)
- E-Mail: smills@ethz.ch
  - Ask about anything (content questions, session feedback, life, etc.)
  - Will send out slides and material via e-mail

What is Information Retrieval about?

- It‘s about retrieving information (duh!)
  - Querying, Ranking
- It‘s about (efficiently) storing information

Course Layout

Introduction Boolean queries Term vocabulary and posting lists Tolerant retrieval	**Basics of Information Retrieval**
Scale up Index construction Index compression Ranked retrieval Scoring optimization Evaluation	**Advanced topics**
Probabilistic information retrieval Language models Crawling the Web and link analysis	**Alternate methodologies**

Course Information

- **Lecture:** Fridays, 10-12
- **Exercise Session:** Fridays, 16-17
- Lecture and Exercise not happening on: Good Friday (03.04.26), Easter Week (10.04.26) and Labour Day (01.05.26)
- **Moodle:** https://moodle-app2.let.ethz.ch/course/view.php?id=26803
  - All Slides, Videos, Exercises will be uploaded there
  - Can ask questions in the Forum
- **Notebooks:** https://student-jupyter.inf.ethz.ch/hub/spawn
  - Weekly Coding Exercises
  - May be relevant to exam, are very likely to be relevant to bonus quizzes

Exam

- Grade determined fully by final exam
  - Content: Lectures, Notebooks, Quizzes
  - The quizzes give a good picture of what to expect at the exam
  - Book is very good! Use if you want to understand things better
    - https://nlp.stanford.edu/IR-book/information-retrieval-book.html
- Bonus Points possible (+0.25)
  - 3 Bonus quizzes during the semester
  - Full bonus: Pass 2/3 quizzes
  - Each quiz may ask questions from notebooks as well as lectures

Notebooks

- Weekly Exercises furthering knowledge about lectures
- Test now if it works: https://student-jupyter.inf.ethz.ch/hub/spawn
- Coding in Python

Kahoot

https://create.kahoot.it/share/information-retrieval-introduction/4e5bc650-e58a-402b-9a63-55bd99ed6496